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REL 101: Introduction to the Study of Religion

Describe religious traditions accurately before you evaluate them

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Religion & Human Relations | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

This pack introduces the academic study of religion: key terms, the major traditions present in Nigeria, African Traditional Religion without caricature, and the method of describing before evaluating. It also covers the ethics of studying living communities.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Define religion, belief, ritual and sacred with reference to scholars.
- Compare Christianity, Islam and African Traditional Religion accurately.
- Apply the describe-then-analyse method.
- Follow ethical norms in fieldwork with religious communities.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Terms that need defining

Definitions shape what you notice.

- Religion: a contested category; substantive and functional definitions differ.
- Belief, practice, community and institution as four dimensions.
- Sacred and profane; purity, taboo and boundary.
- Ritual: repetitive, patterned action with symbolic meaning.
- Myth: a foundational narrative, not a synonym for falsehood.
- Syncretism, conversion and revival as processes, not labels.

Traditions in Nigeria

Accuracy beats generalisation.

- Christianity: denominational diversity, Pentecostal growth and independent churches.
- Islam: Maliki jurisprudence in the north, Sufi orders, reform movements.
- African Traditional Religion: a misleading singular term for diverse traditions with shared features - divination, ancestors, deities, community rites.
- Interreligious relations and conflict, and the role of the state.
- Internal diversity within every tradition; avoid treating one expression as the whole.
- Use the names communities use for themselves.

> **Describe, then evaluate**
> Describe a practice in the terms its practitioners use, then analyse it with your academic tools. Reversing the order produces caricature.

Method and ethics

Religion is studied, not proselytised.

- Bracketing: set aside your own commitments for the purposes of description.
- Use insider and outsider accounts together.
- Obtain consent before interviews and photography.
- Anonymise where disclosure could expose or endanger participants.
- Distinguish normative theology from descriptive religious studies.
- Cite sources with their tradition and date.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why is 'African Traditional Religion' a contested singular term?

Answer: It groups diverse, locally distinct traditions under one label, obscuring their differences and histories.

2. What does bracketing mean in the study of religion?

Answer: Setting aside one's own commitments temporarily in order to describe a tradition accurately on its own terms.

3. Give two dimensions of religion besides belief.

Answer: Practice and community; institution and ritual are further dimensions.

4. Distinguish theology from religious studies.

Answer: Theology argues from within a tradition; religious studies describes and analyses traditions as an academic field.

5. Name one fieldwork ethics requirement.

Answer: Informed consent before interviews or photography, plus protection of participant confidentiality.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write two definitions of religion from different scholars.
- [ ] Compare three traditions across four dimensions.
- [ ] Learn ten terms with examples.
- [ ] Visit a service or site with permission and take descriptive notes.
- [ ] Write a description with no evaluative language.
- [ ] Then write a separate analytical section.
- [ ] Check every claim against a cited source.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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